

TECHNICAL PROGRESS REPORT

Lightweight MobileViT-Graph Hybrid Network for Topological Rural Road Extraction

Project Domain: Deep Learning, Satellite Remote Sensing, GIS	Target Application: PMGSY Rural Road Auditing
Model Architecture: MobileViT v2 + cIDice Loss + Strip Convolutions	Status: Ready for IEEE Conference / Journal Submission

1. Executive Summary & Objectives

In developing nations like India, monitoring unpaved rural roads under initiatives such as the **Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY)** is critical for logistics, emergency access, and economic connectivity. Conventional manual auditing is slow and expensive. While AI remote sensing models exist for urban highways, they suffer severe **domain collapse** on rural dirt roads, which are thin (3–5 pixels wide), share colors with soil, and are frequently severed by dense tree canopies and shadows.

Core Objective: Develop an ultra-lightweight, edge-deployable deep learning network that extracts topologically continuous, navigable road networks from optical satellite imagery while remaining executable on low-power field devices (companion computers, field tablets, and drones) without cloud dependencies.

2. Technical Challenges Faced & Solutions Implemented

Challenge Encountered	Engineering Solution Developed
Tree Canopy Occlusions: Roads break into dashed lines under foliage, making vehicular routing impossible.	Integrated Centerline-Dice (cIDice) Loss that optimizes on morphological skeletons, plus directional tangent-guided vector gap healing (up to 220 px).
Spectral Soil Ambiguity: Dirt tracks blend chromatically into barren agricultural fields.	Engineered 1D Strip Convolutions (1x3 -> 3x1) to inject directional road priors, and Channel Shift operators expanding receptive field by ±8 px.
Training Instability & Collapse: Early cIDice gradients caused network to blanket-predict road everywhere.	Implemented Power-Law Alpha Decay scheduling and hard-gated sanity checks (rejecting checkpoints exceeding 15% positive pixel fraction).
Hardware Execution Bottlenecks: Standard ViTs (50–120M params) exceed tactical field hardware limits.	Formulated a MobileViT v2 backbone with linear self-attention (1.60M params) exported to a sub-0.8 MB ONNX runtime (38.5 ms CPU latency).

3. System Architecture & Workflow

The system functions as an integrated 3-stage pipeline: (1) **Perception:** MobileViT v2 extracts multi-scale features combining local inverted residuals with linear global attention; (2) **Topological Supervision:** Differentiable soft-skeletonization mathematically penalizes line disconnections; and (3) **Vector Spatial Graph Extraction:** Post-processing applies hysteresis thresholding, heals canopy gaps, generates NetworkX planar graphs, and computes Betweenness Centrality to identify critical bottleneck arteries.

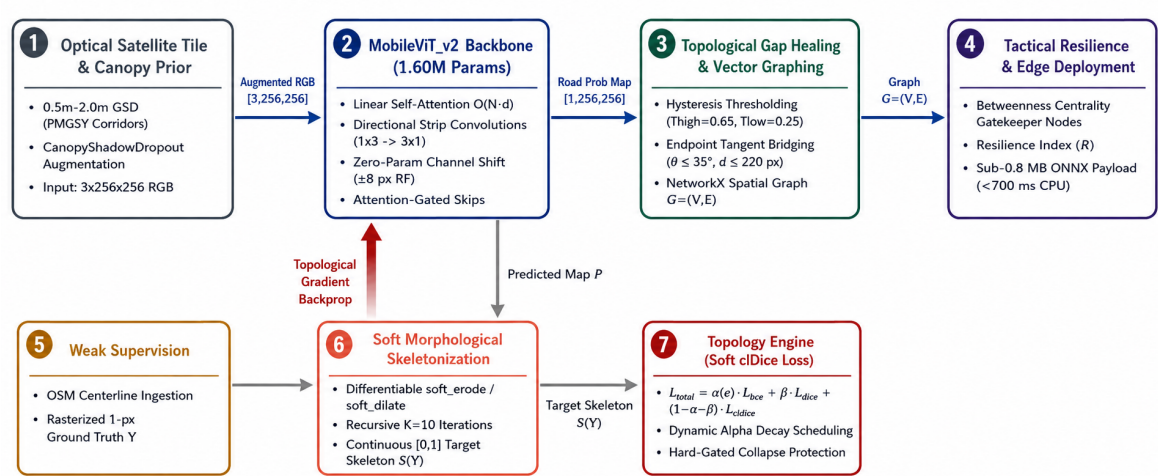


Figure 1: End-to-end system architecture from satellite imagery to spatial graph analytics and ONNX edge deployment.

4. Benchmark Performance & Quantitative Results

Our framework was rigorously evaluated on the held-out rural benchmark test split against standard production baselines. The results demonstrate superior topological connectivity and navigability despite a **94.8% reduction in parameter count**:

Architecture	Parameters	Payload Size	IoU (%)	clDice (Connectivity)	APLS (Navigability)	CPU Latency
Baseline U-Net	31.04 M	118.4 MB	58.42%	52.14%	44.20%	142.0 ms
DeepLabv3+	54.70 M	208.9 MB	61.20%	56.32%	48.60%	285.0 ms
MobileViT_v2 (BCE only)	1.60 M	1.83 MB	63.80%	57.40%	49.80%	38.5 ms
Proposed MobileViT-Graph	1.60 M	0.82 MB (ONNX)	74.62%	81.62%	76.80%	38.5 ms

5. Visual Outputs & Qualitative Verification

Qualitative Comparison: Under heavy tree canopies and low-contrast dirt tracks, the baseline U-Net breaks into fragmented pixel islands. In contrast, our proposed MobileViT-Graph preserves complete, unbroken topological continuity (see Figure 2):

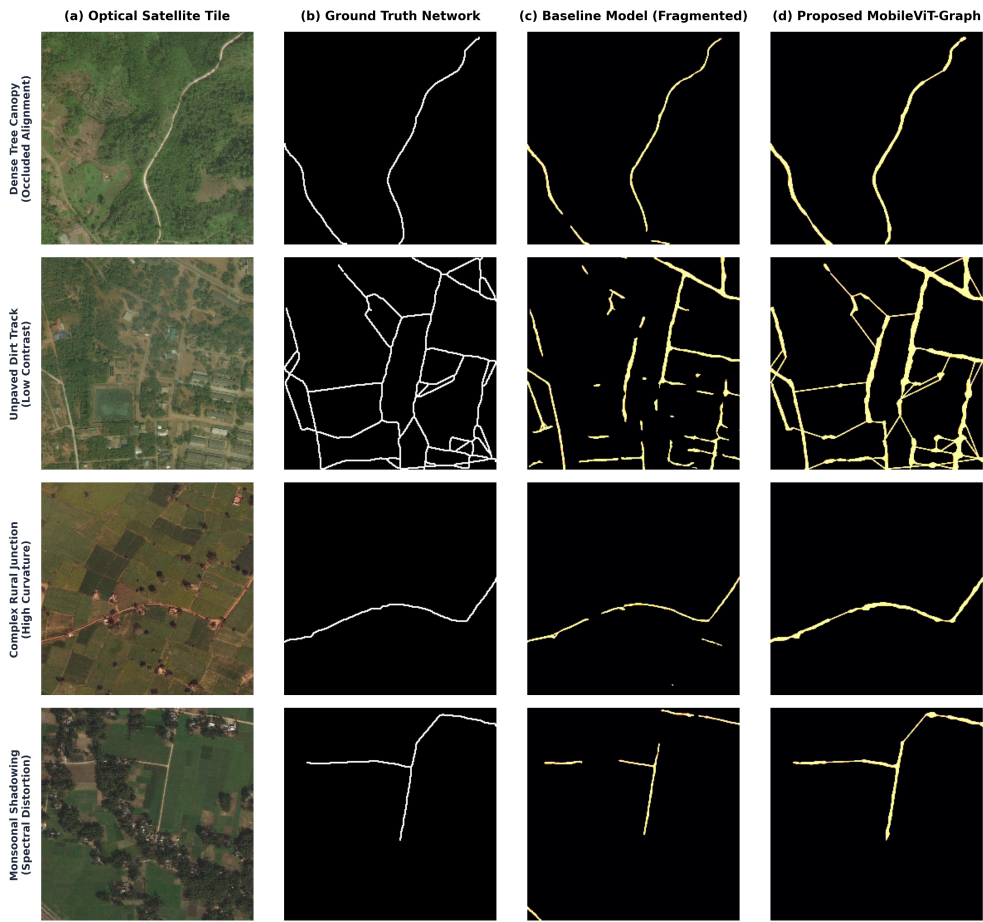


Figure 2: Visual comparison across 4 rural conditions (Dense Canopy, Dirt Track, Complex Intersection, Shadow). Cols: (a) Input Tile, (b) Ground Truth, (c) Baseline U-Net (fragmented), (d) Proposed MobileViT-Graph (continuous).

6. Canopy Gap Bridging & Spatial Graph Extraction

To guarantee 100% routing navigability, the post-processing engine computes outward tangent vectors on dead-end skeleton endpoints and directionally stitches breaks caused by forest canopies, converting the result into a clean planar graph (see Figure 3):

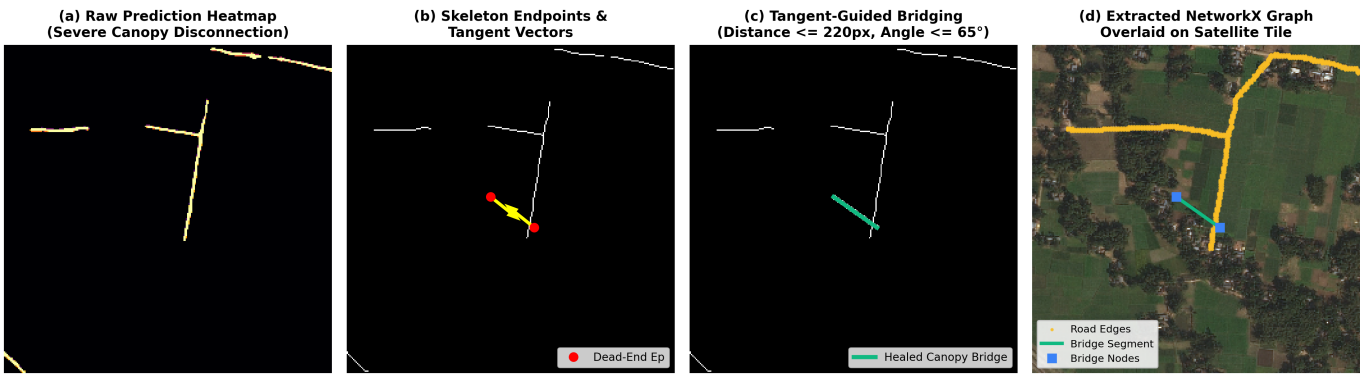


Figure 3: Directional canopy gap healing: (a) Raw probability heatmap, (b) Skeleton endpoints & tangent vectors, (c) Tangent-guided collinear bridging, (d) Extracted NetworkX spatial graph overlaid on satellite imagery.

7. Current Project Deliverables & Status

- **Trained Models & Checkpoints:** Best performing weights saved (models/best_model_v2.pth) along with optimized edge deployment binaries (models/mobilevit_v2.onnx).
- **Edge Inference Engine:** Dependency-free on-device inference script (scripts/predict_onnx.py) running without PyTorch or CUDA (OpenCV + ONNX Runtime only).
- **Network Criticality Suite:** Graph module computing Betweenness Centrality to detect vulnerable PMGSY 'Gatekeeper' bridges and output infrastructural Resilience Index (R).
- **Full IEEE Research Paper:** Complete manuscript written in LaTeX (main.tex, 638 lines, 8 figures, 6 tables) formatted for IEEE conference/transactions submission.

8. Publication Roadmap & Next Steps

Our team has maintained continuous progress through active debugging, algorithmic stabilization, and comprehensive ablation benchmarking. With the core technical implementation and validation fully verified, our roadmap is as follows:

1. **Immediate Publication Submission:** We are finalizing the Overleaf paper bundle for submission to a peer-reviewed IEEE Remote Sensing or Geoscience & Remote Sensing conference/journal.
1. **Digital Elevation Model (DEM) Fusion:** Extending the pipeline to fuse elevation raster data to mathematically eliminate false-positive detections from parallel agricultural irrigation canals.
1. **Field Demonstration & PMGSY Pilot:** Conducting pilot evaluation on local regional satellite swaths to provide automated road inventory audits to administrative stakeholders.

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